

Special Focus Topic

Free-to-play in 2026

To challenge the narrative that free-to-play (F2P) is dying, our expert analysts examined shifts in playtime, genres, revenue concentration, and the rise of gacha across PC and console.

Introduction

Contrary to current opinion, F2P is not in severe decline. Overall hours have remained broadly flat, but the market is changing across platforms. Console decline is concentrated in established live-service titles, while PC growth is being driven by gacha RPGs. That growth is reshuffling an existing audience and has not yet translated into proportionate revenue for F2P games, which is where the commercial opportunities could lie.

Scope and definitions

- Our analysis uses [Newzoo's Game Performance Monitor](#), covering PC and console engagement across 37 markets, excluding China and India.
- Revenue analysis covers the US, UK, Germany, France, Spain, and Italy.
- Gacha refers to progression-based loot box monetization.

Seven groups tracked*

Free-to-play

Premium live-service

Other premium

Call of Duty

Roblox

Fortnite

Minecraft

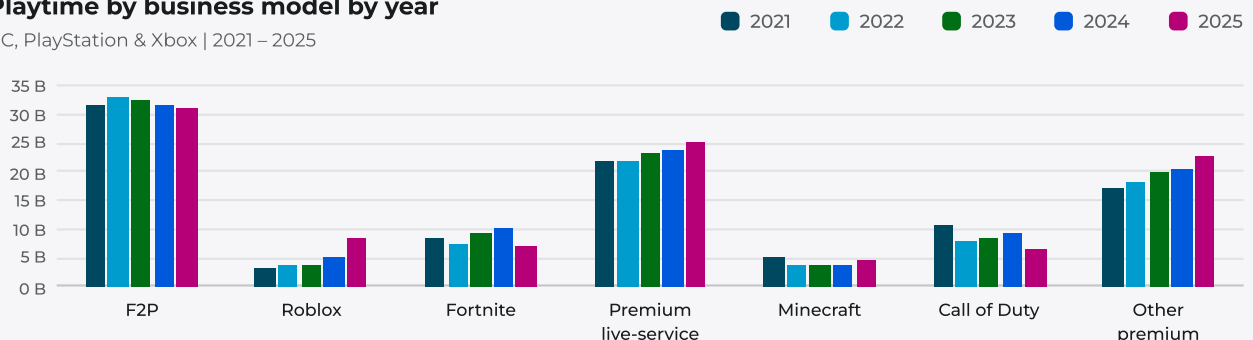
*Note: *Call of Duty*, *Roblox*, *Fortnite*, and *Minecraft* are tracked individually so their scale does not distort the other groups.

The market-level view: F2P hours are flat, not falling

Our analysis starts with total playtime shares across the seven groups we tracked.

Playtime by business model by year

PC, PlayStation & Xbox | 2021 – 2025



Hours share 2025

29.3%

7.9%

7.0%

23.6%

4.6%

6.0%

21.6%

Δ hours share (pp) 2025 vs 2021

-2.9

+4.6

-1.4

+1.2

-0.6

-4.9

+4.0

Source: Newzoo Game Performance Monitor | 37 markets (excluding China and India)

F2P playtime share fell 2.9 percentage points between 2021 and 2025, but absolute hours remained broadly flat. F2P's share drop came more from the market growing around it (including premium games and *Roblox*) and less from losing playtime. Losses were concentrated among a handful of competitive titles, while premium and premium live-service gained absolute hours.

PC and console tell different versions of the same story

Splitting the market by platform reveals two different stories of F2P health.

PC

F2P playtime grew on PC even as its market share declined. Growth elsewhere, particularly from *Roblox* and lower-priced premium releases, made the category appear weaker than its underlying hours suggest.

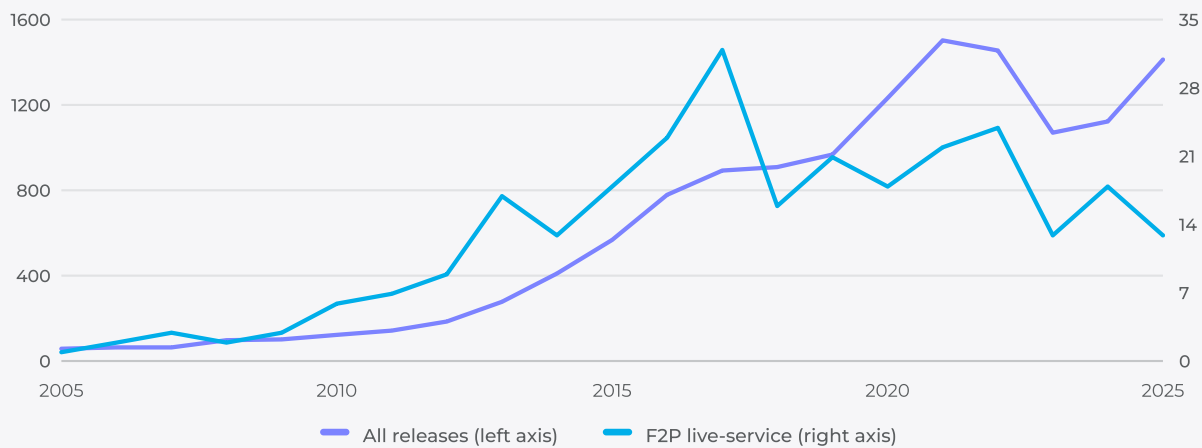
Console

On console, the decline in F2P playtime is real, but it is concentrated rather than category-wide. A handful of established live-service titles account for much of the contraction, rather than a broad collapse of the model.

F2P live-service launches have slowed sharply

Number of titles by release year, the market vs. F2P live-service

PC, PlayStation & Xbox | 2005 – 2025



Source: Newzoo Game Performance Monitor | 37 markets (excluding China and India)

F2P live-service launches peaked at 36 titles in 2017 and have declined steadily since. The annual average fell from 21.3 titles in 2020–2022 to 14.7 in 2023–2025, a 31% drop, even as releases increased across the wider market.

Rising costs, greater risks, and established competitive titles have made it harder for new F2P live-service titles to break through. Within this more selective launch environment, gacha RPGs have become the main area of F2P growth on PC.

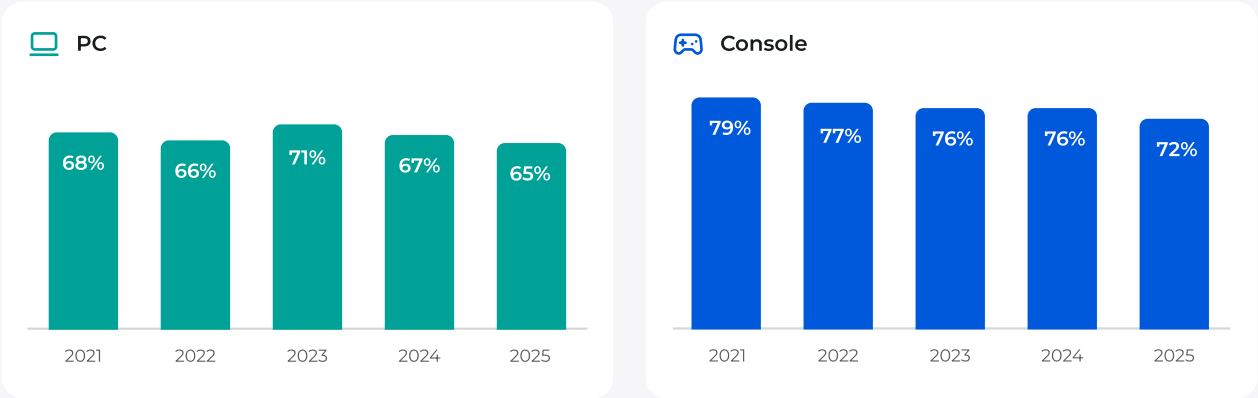
The full *Free-to-Play in 2026* Special Focus Topic is available with a **Games Market Reports & Forecasts** subscription. The report includes in-depth data and insights that explore platform-level engagement trends, regional playtime patterns, revenue concentration across game rankings, gacha engagement and revenue patterns, and more.

[Find out more](#)

Revenue is shifting away from the top of the charts

Revenue share by year within the top 5 titles

PC, PlayStation & Xbox | 2021 – 2025



Source: Newzoo Game Performance Monitor | 6 markets

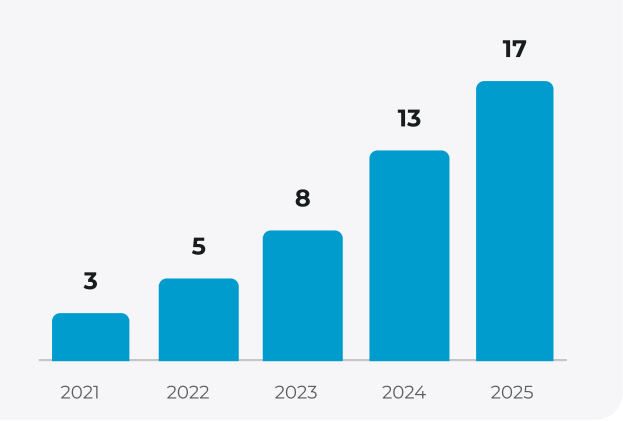
F2P revenue is becoming less concentrated among the highest-ranked titles on both PC and console.

Between 2021 and 2025, ranks 1–5 lost share on both platforms, with console, including *Roblox*, falling 7.3 percentage points, more than twice the decline on PC. This challenges the perception that F2P spending is consolidating around a handful of dominant games. As revenue moves further down the rankings, the F2P revenue landscape is becoming less concentrated around the top tier.

Progression has become the primary hook in new F2P titles

Number of tracked major gacha titles on PC and console

PC, PlayStation & Xbox | 2021 – 2025



Source: Newzoo Game Performance Monitor | 37 markets (excluding China and India)

As more major gacha titles reach PC and console, F2P is shifting away from titles built on competitive gameplay, which require thousands of hours to master and reward optional cosmetic spend. Instead, newer games increasingly use progression systems tied to characters, weapons, and upgrades, with drip-fed rewards linked directly to player spending.

The effect is strongest on PC, where gacha playtime grew 92% between 2021 and 2025, adding 864 million hours. By contrast, console gacha added 85 million hours in the same period and spent two of those years shrinking.

Gacha RPGs are driving F2P engagement on PC, but audience overlap suggests much of this growth comes from players moving between titles in the category. For publishers, the opportunity is to understand which audiences can be retained and monetized.

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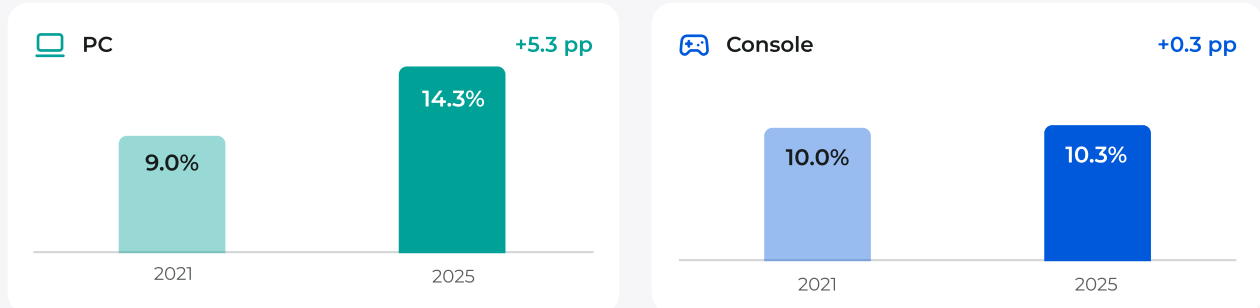
[Find out more](#)

RPGs show genuine growth on PC, but only modest gains on console

RPG was the only F2P genre to gain share on both platforms, largely driven by gacha titles. But the scale and nature of that growth differed considerably.

RPG share of F2P playtime, 2021 vs. 2025

PC, PlayStation & Xbox



Source: Newzoo Game Performance Monitor | 37 markets (excluding China and India)

The RPG share on PC rose 5.3 percentage points to 14.3%, the largest gain among PC F2P genres. Newer gacha RPGs drove most of this expansion: *Wuthering Waves*, *Honkai: Star Rail*, and *Zenless Zone Zero* added a combined 1.1 billion hours by 2025.

The RPG genre grew only modestly on console, edging up from 10.0% to 10.3%, but the composition mirrors PC. Newer titles gained ground as they launched on console, including *Zenless Zone Zero*, *Wuthering Waves*, and *Honkai: Star Rail*, while *Genshin Impact* fell.

Conclusion

F2P is not dying. Instead, it is evolving in different ways across PC and console. While some established live-service games have lost momentum, overall engagement has remained resilient, with progression-focused experiences such as gacha RPGs capturing a growing share of player attention. But growing attention has not yet translated into proportional revenue gains, highlighting a widening gap between engagement and monetization. For developers and publishers, the challenge is no longer proving that players still want F2P games. It is understanding how player behavior is changing, and how to turn that engagement into sustainable commercial success.



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